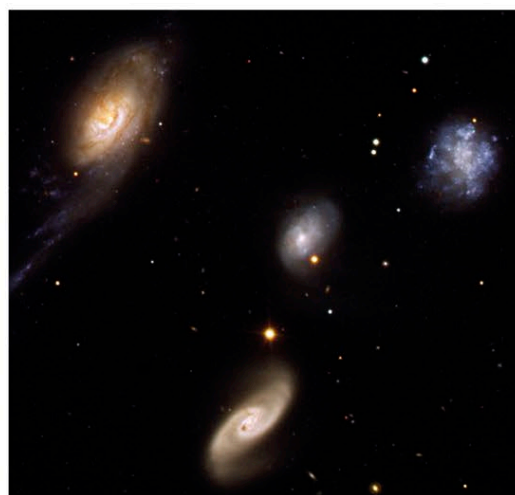


PHOENIX

THE PHOENIX

DEPICTING A MYTHICAL BIRD, THE PHOENIX, THIS INDISTINCT CONSTELLATION WAS DEvised IN THE 16TH CENTURY. IT LIES BETWEEN SCULPTOR TO THE NORTH AND TUCANA TO THE SOUTH.

According to legend, the phoenix lived for hundreds of years, died in flames, and a young phoenix was born from its ashes. The constellation was devised by Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman. Ankaa marks the bird's beak at the north end of a rectangle that forms its body, with open wings at either side. Phoenix has interesting double stars and two of the most massive galaxy clusters known: the Phoenix Cluster and the El Gordo Cluster.



△ Robert's Quartet

This is a group of four galaxies about 160 million light-years away that are interacting. They are an irregular galaxy (right) and three spiral galaxies. An arm of the largest spiral (top left) has been distorted and the galaxy has at least 200 areas of intense star formation. There is a diffuse area of material around the central galaxy, and the one below it has two spiral arms.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 37
Brightest stars Alpha (α) 2.4, Beta (β) 3.3
Genitive Phoenicis
Abbreviation Phe
Highest in sky at 10pm October–November
Fully visible 32°N–90°S



CHART 3

MAIN STARS

Ankaa Alpha (α) Phoenicis
 Orange giant

☼ 2.4 ↔ 85 light-years

Beta (β) Phoenicis
 Yellow giant

☼ 3.3 ↔ 225 light-years

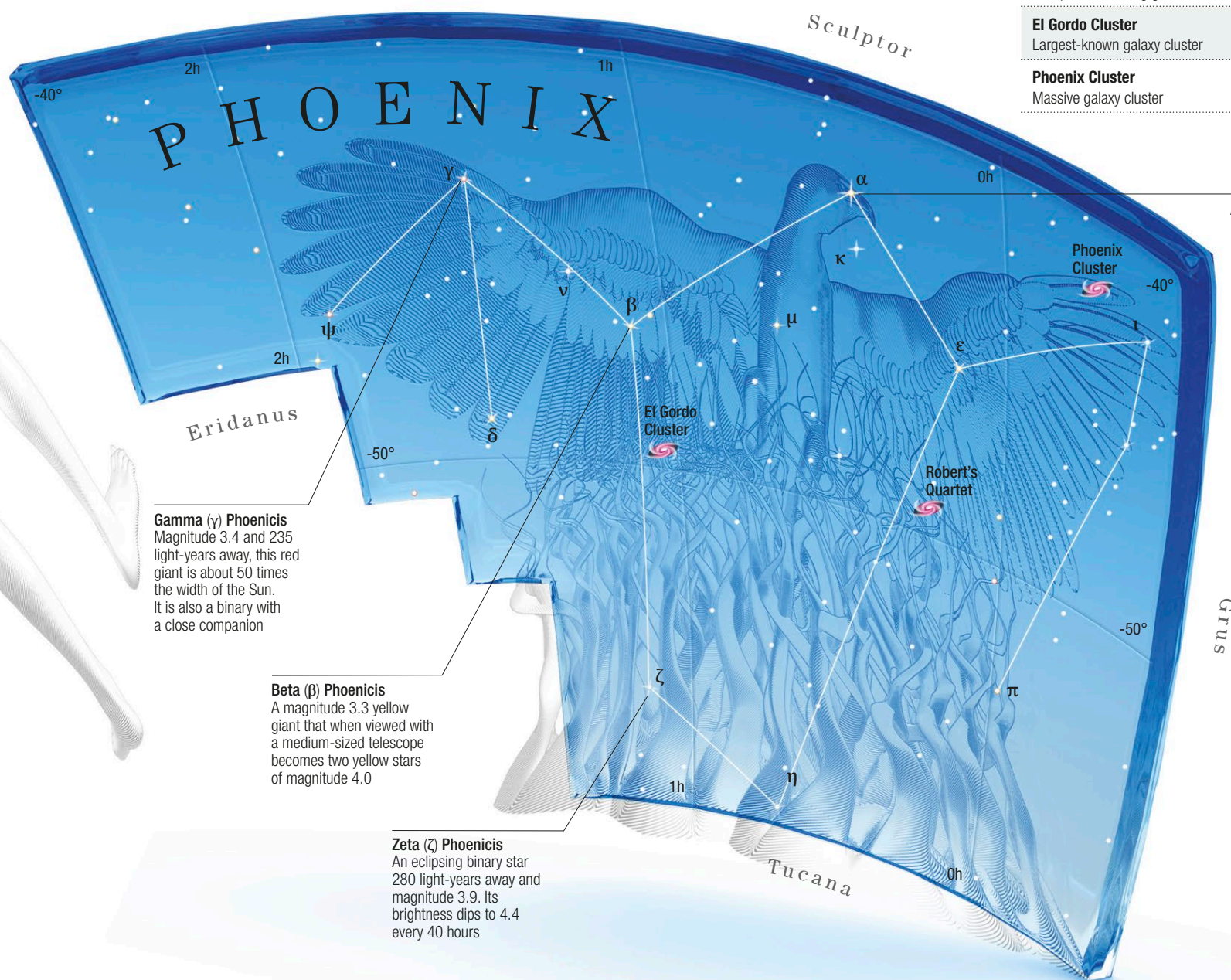
DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

Robert's Quartet
 Group of interacting galaxies

El Gordo Cluster
 Largest-known galaxy cluster

Phoenix Cluster
 Massive galaxy cluster

Ankaa (α Phoenicis)
 An orange giant about 15 times the width of the Sun. It is Phoenix's brightest star, at magnitude 2.4



Gamma (γ) Phoenicis
 Magnitude 3.4 and 235 light-years away, this red giant is about 50 times the width of the Sun. It is also a binary with a close companion

Beta (β) Phoenicis
 A magnitude 3.3 yellow giant that when viewed with a medium-sized telescope becomes two yellow stars of magnitude 4.0

Zeta (ζ) Phoenicis
 An eclipsing binary star 280 light-years away and magnitude 3.9. Its brightness dips to 4.4 every 40 hours